



BEFORE

Early on in the war, the Confederate government decided not to defend the entire coast but instead to concentrate its efforts on holding the major harbors.

VITAL PORT

After the [loss of New Orleans](#) in April 1862, Mobile became the principal Confederate port on the Gulf Coast and the base for the **blockade-runners operating the important link with Cuba** that brought in much-needed supplies.

IRONCLAD BATTLE

The first clash between armored ships, or "ironclads," was the inconclusive [Battle of Hampton Roads](#) in **March 1862**. In this famous engagement CSS *Virginia*, an iron-plated warship commanded by Admiral Franklin Buchanan, took on the newly designed, shallow-draft USS *Monitor*, but neither could inflict significant damage on the other. **Buchanan led the Southern force** at Mobile Bay.

The Battle of Mobile Bay was a significant defeat for the Confederacy. It was fought principally on August 5, 1864, though follow-up actions continued later into the month.

Mobile Bay is located where the Mobile and Tensaw rivers meet before they enter the Gulf of Mexico. Before the Civil War, as part of a plan to strengthen its coastal defenses, the United States government had erected three forts to shield Mobile from possible enemy fleets. Standing at the mouth of Mobile Bay was the massive Fort Morgan, a brick edifice completed in 1834 and defended by 46 guns and a garrison of 600. Pentagonal-shaped Fort Gaines was situated on Dauphin Island, directly opposite Fort Morgan. Fort Gaines mounted 26 guns and could also accommodate 600 troops. The smallest of the three was Fort Powell, with 18 guns and space for 140 troops. Although the forts were well positioned to repel any seaborne invasion, they were vulnerable to an assault from their rear.

Farragut's mission in 1864 was to destroy the Confederate fleet in Alabama, commanded by Admiral Franklin Buchanan. His small fleet included the formidable ironclad CSS *Tennessee*, with its heavy armor plating, and three smaller ships; Farragut commanded four monitors and 14 wooden vessels. In the light of dawn on August 5, Farragut concluded that conditions were ideal to attack.